

Madagascar



MADAGASCAR is the fourth largest island in the world. It was once attached to mainland Africa, but it split off and drifted away tens of millions of years ago. This long period of isolation has allowed many unique animals to develop there, including tenrecs, lemurs, and two-thirds of the world's chameleons. In contrast, some common animal groups, such as woodpeckers and venomous snakes, do not occur on the island at all.

One of the reasons for the wide range of wildlife on Madagascar is its varied climate and vegetation. The east coast has a tropical rainforest, but the extreme south of the island is drier, with semidesert conditions. Mountains run down the island, and the high central plateau is relatively cold, covered with grassy savannah.

Ring-tailed lemur
(*Lemur catta*)
Body length: up to 18 in (46 cm)
Tail: up to 29 in (63 cm)



Smelly signals

The ring-tailed lemur produces a scent, which it uses to mark its territory and tell rival lemurs to keep out. The male ring-tail also uses his scent in "stink fights" with other males. He spreads scent from the glands on his wrists and armpits over his tail, then shakes his tail over his back to fan the smell toward his rival. Lemurs feed on fruit, leaves, tree bark, and grass.

Clever climber

The fosa's tail is almost as long as its body, and helps it balance when climbing trees. Its prey includes lemurs and other mammals, birds, reptiles, and insects. The fosa is the most widespread carnivore on Madagascar, although when humans introduced cats and dogs to the island, they also exposed the fosa to diseases.



Fosa
(*Cryptoprocta ferox*)
Body length: up to 2 ft 8 in (80 cm)
Tail: up to 2 ft 3 in (70 cm)

Common sunbird-asity
(*Neodrepanis coruscans*)
Length: up to 4 in (10.5 cm)



Sugar straw

The common sunbird-asity uses its long, curved beak to reach the nectar inside flowers, and laps it up with the brush-like tip of its tongue. As it feeds, it carries pollen from one flower to the next and helps pollinate them. In the mating season, the male sunbird-asity develops bare blue skin on the sides of his head, probably to attract females for mating.

Verreaux's sifaka
(*Propithecus verreauxi*)
Body length: up to 19 in (48 cm)
Tail: up to 24 in (60 cm)



Strange call

The sifaka's name comes from the strange call it makes to warn other sifakas of danger—"shi-fakh! shi-fakh!" The sifaka's legs are much longer than its arms and help it make amazing leaps of more than 16 ft (5 m) through the trees. The sifaka comes down to the ground occasionally and hops on its back feet with its arms waving wildly over its head. It cannot run on all fours; its arms are too short.

Largest litter

The female tail-less tenrec produces the largest litter of any mammal—up to 32 young. Only about 16–20 usually survive. To frighten away enemies, the tenrec raises the spines and stiff hair on its head and back, stamps its front feet, hisses, and opens its mouth wide.



Tail-less tenrec
(*Tenrec ecaudatus*)
Body length: up to 14 in (35 cm)

Aye-aye
(*Daubentonia madagascariensis*)
Head and body: up to 15 in (37 cm)
Tail: up to 21 in (53 cm)



Oversized ears

The forest-dwelling aye-aye is a type of lemur with huge, bat-like ears. Its hearing is so good that it can detect insects moving beneath the bark of trees. It uses its long, spindly middle finger to pull out juicy grubs, and also eats plant food, such as nuts, bamboo shoots, and fruit. The aye-aye is endangered due to the destruction of its habitat.